

EVIDENT AI INDEX PAYMENTS

The global standard benchmark of AI maturity

KEY FINDINGS
REPORT

2026/02

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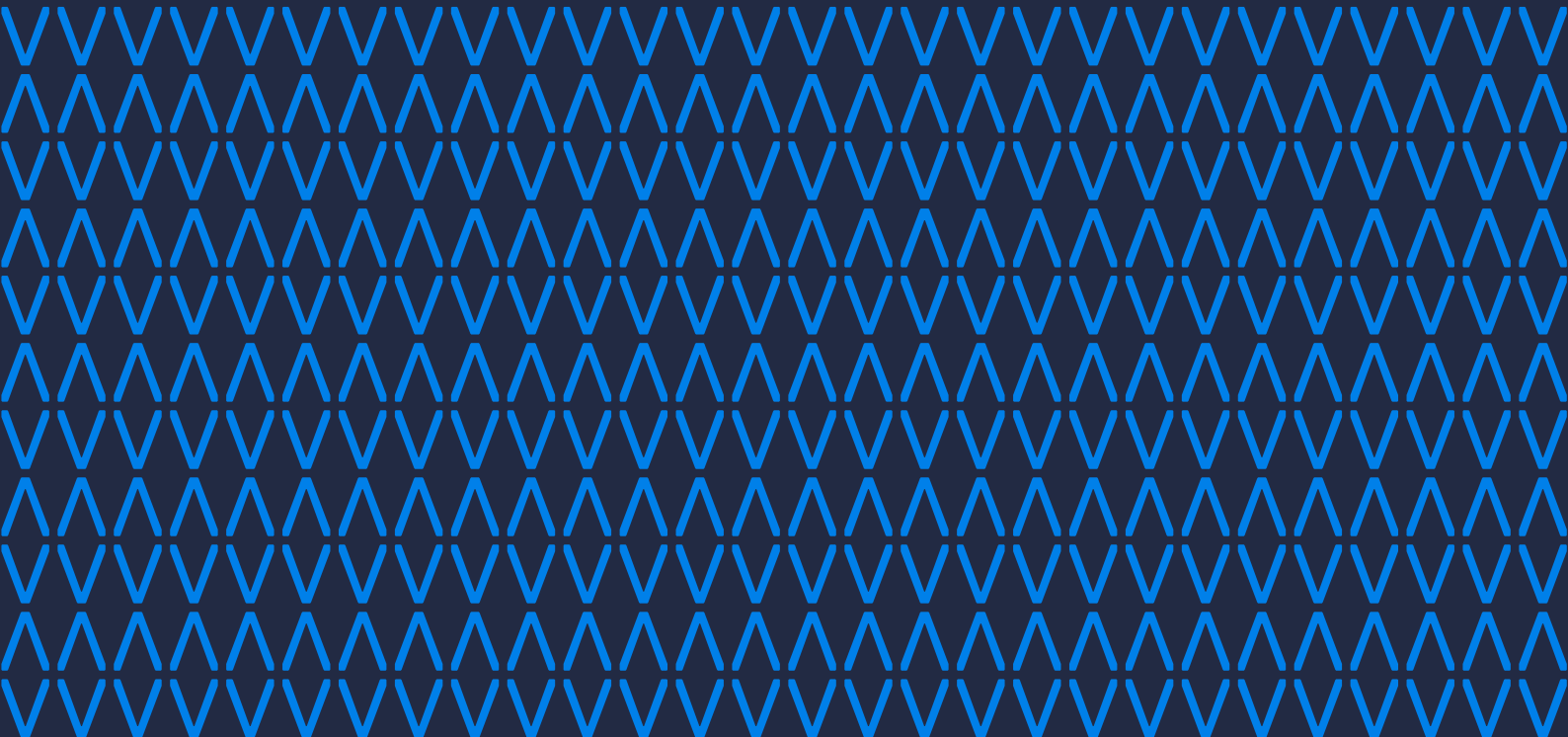
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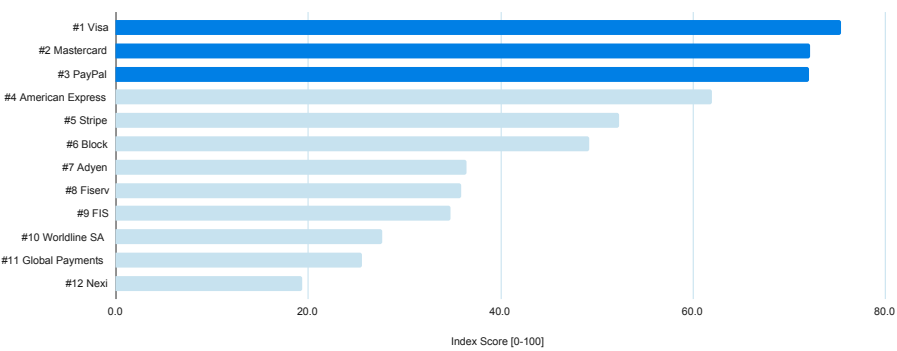
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1 BALANCED, CONSISTENT INVESTMENT DEFINE INDEX LEADERS
Visa, Mastercard, and PayPal lead Evident’s inaugural rankings of AI maturity within the payments sector. These leaders demonstrate a high degree of consistency across each pillar of the Index – decisively outpacing their peers in three of the four areas of assessment: *Talent, Innovation, and Transparency.*

February 2026

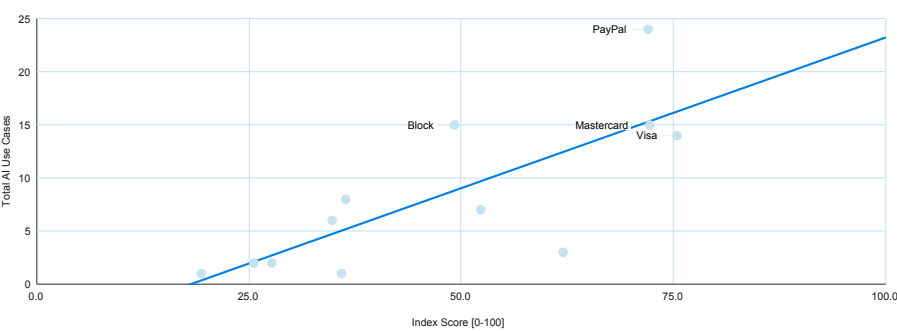
EVIDENT AI INDEX | PAYMENTS: OVERALL SCORE IN EVIDENT AI INDEX



2 AI ENABLERS DRIVE OUTCOMES
Over the past two years, the 12 payment companies assessed documented nearly 100 AI use cases in press releases or investor relations materials. These are not evenly (or randomly) distributed. Payment companies with higher Index scores drove a larger share of the use cases found, demonstrating how sustained investment in AI enablers are accelerating use case production.

January 2024-2026, n=98 AI use cases

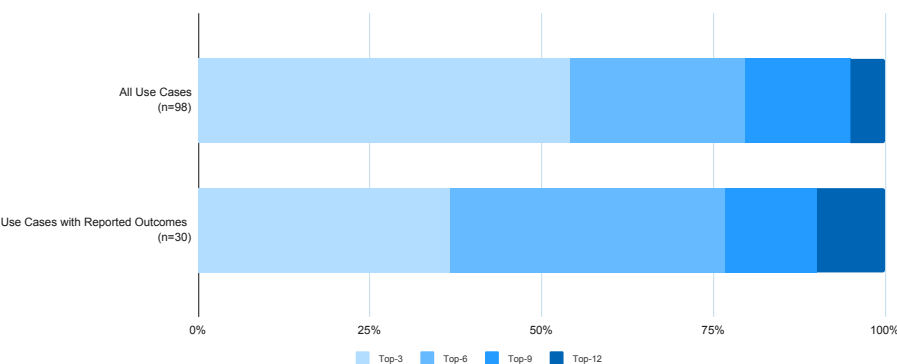
PUBLICLY DISCLOSED AI USE CASES, BY PAYMENT COMPANY



3 AI USE CASES CLUSTERED WITH INDEX LEADERS
Over the past year, nearly a third of AI use cases highlighted in press releases and investor relations materials specify reported outcomes. Firms in the top half of the Index account for nearly 80% of these disclosures, underscoring the link between overall AI maturity and the ability to scale use cases with demonstrable ROI.

January 2025-2026,
n=12 payment companies

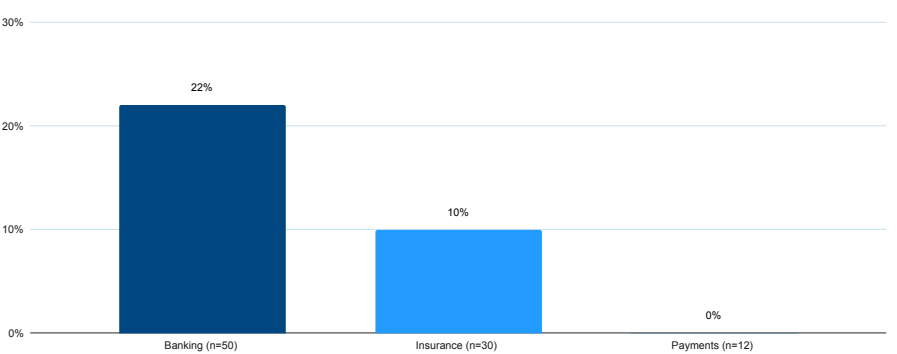
SHARE OF AI USE CASES, BY RANK POSITION IN THE EVIDENT AI INDEX



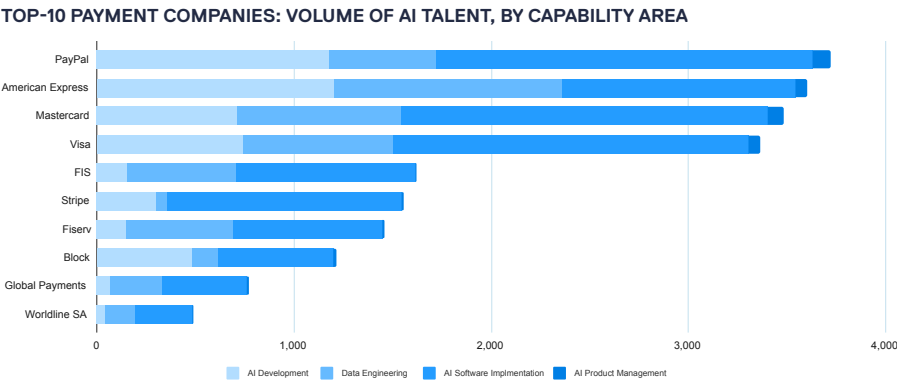
4 LIMITED REPORTING OF OVERALL AI:ROI
Unlike the progressive disclosures we see unfolding in the banking industry, no payment company has (yet) to disclose realized or projected ROI across all AI activities. Many might easily mistake this for a sign of immaturity, whereas AI enhancements to payments infrastructure is often “baked” into established KPIs (lower fraud rates, higher approval rates, and lower costs per transaction).

February 2026,
n=92 Financial Services Companies

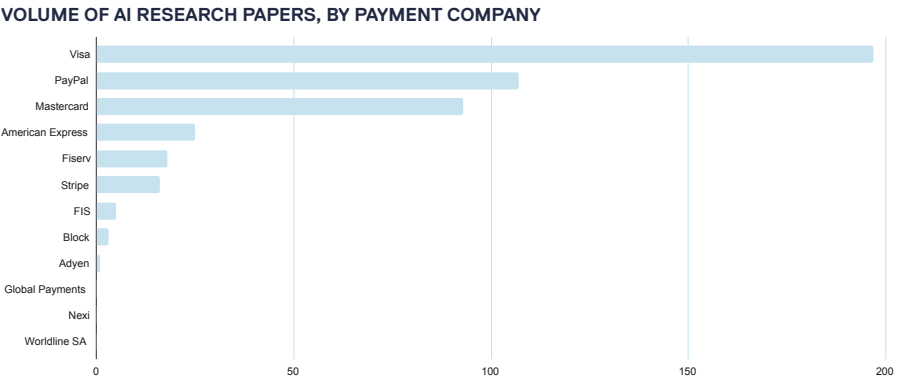
SHARE OF COMPANIES REPORTING ROI FROM AI ACTIVITIES (REALIZED OR PROJECTED), BY SECTOR



5 25% OF INDEX = 50% OF TALENT
The three major card networks account for nearly half (48%) of the talent stack shared across the Payments Index. American Express has the most AI Developers, owing to the closed-loop nature of its network. Meanwhile, PayPal boasts 2.9x as much AI talent volume compared to other processors, owing to the breadth and depth of AI specialization within its diverse product portfolio.

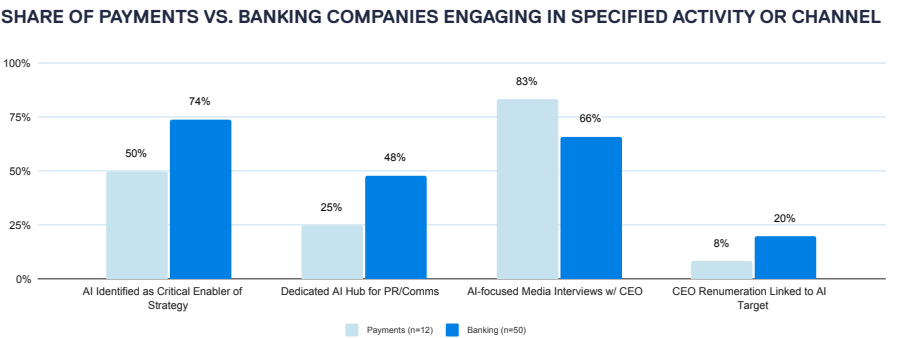


6 INDEX LEADERS DOMINATE RESEARCH
While three quarters of payments companies have published AI research over the last three years, output remains highly concentrated. Visa, PayPal, and Mastercard account for 85% of published work – signalling the pressure to defend trust, drive differentiation, and shape customer value through continuing innovation.



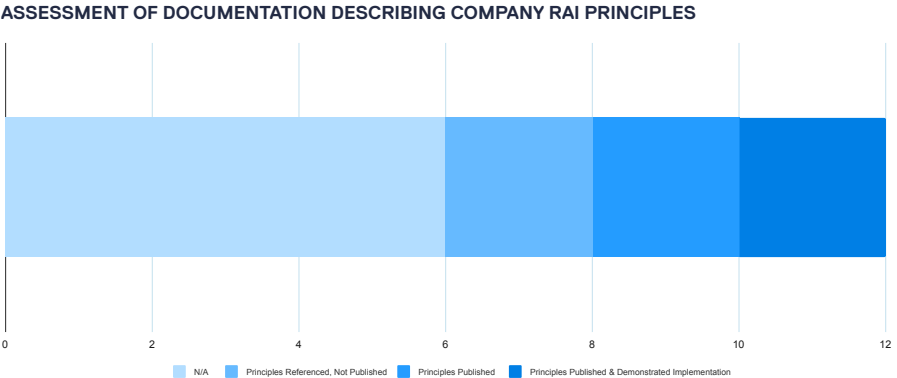
February 2023-2026, n=465 publications

7 CEOS PROVE INSTRUMENTAL IN MESSAGING AI STRATEGY
Only half of payment companies call out AI as a critical enabler of business objectives in strategic documents or investor relations materials. As we wait for a first-mover to disclose more comprehensive AI:ROI measures, the industry remains more reliant on CEOs to message major milestones with respect to AI strategy.



February 2026, n=12 Payment Companies

8 ONLY 1-IN-3 PUBLISH RAI PRINCIPLES
Although half of payment companies explicitly allude to Responsible AI principals in strategy documents or external communications, only a third openly publish these tenets – and only Mastercard and PayPal go the extra mile in demonstrating active operational implementation.



February 2026, n=12 payment companies

Evident is the leading intelligence platform for AI in financial services. We benchmark deployment across the sector, spotlight emerging trends, and equip leaders with the insights they need to accelerate AI transformation.

Businesses worldwide are ratcheting up AI investment. Those that race ahead will challenge their rivals on growth, productivity, and financial performance. Those that fall behind risk irrelevance in a rapidly changing marketplace. And yet, despite the high stakes, visibility into how companies are approaching AI transformation remains limited.

We believe transparency is critical to realizing the full potential of AI for commercial – and societal – gain. By showcasing best practice, we help companies transform faster and more safely, minimizing the harms of AI, whilst maximizing its commercial, economic, and societal opportunities.

The Evident AI Index is now the global standard benchmark of AI maturity for financial services. It is the most comprehensive and trusted benchmark of its kind, covering 50 of the world's largest [banks](#), 30 leading [insurers](#) and - now – 12 major [payment networks and processors](#).

At the heart of the Evident AI Index is independence. Our methodology relies exclusively on publicly available data. This “outside-in” approach enables us to build a more complete assessment of corporate AI maturity than the narrow survey-based approaches that exist today.

Evident members work with us to enhance competitive intelligence, identify best practices, and define KPIs specific to AI transformation – and ultimately, inform strategic decision-making. Members can benefit from a range of tools, including:

1. Benchmarking

In-depth benchmarking of AI capabilities and outcomes.

Our public Index benchmarking lets firms analyse and accelerate their AI capabilities across all four pillars of AI maturity: Talent, Innovation, Leadership and Transparency. Our private Outcomes benchmarking lets firms gain deeper insight into the performance of their AI investment, ROI, and use cases.

2. Intelligence

[Research reports and data trackers](#) covering the latest sector-wide trends.

Our research provides members with timely, in-depth analysis of the latest use cases, reported outcomes, as well as insights specific to each component of our methodology.

3. Community

[Exclusive events and roundtables](#) for senior AI leaders to connect with peers and share insights, including our flagship annual gathering – the [Evident AI Symposium](#) – taking place in October 2026 in New York City.

Get in touch to find out how we can work together or to share feedback on how we can continue to expand our methodology.

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Sources & Methods

The Evident AI Payments Index ranks the AI maturity of 12 of the largest payment networks and processors across the globe. It is an independent, “outside-in” assessment based exclusively on publicly available information.

These 12 entities were chosen by aggregating the largest payment companies, with a minimum of \$2B in annual revenue. We then evaluated these companies for evidence of both the size and scale of ongoing AI activity, thereby ensuring any resulting ranking would yield balanced, competitive, and dynamic results.

Each company was assessed against 60+ individual indicators, organised into four pillars that we believe are critical to successful AI deployment at scale: Talent, Innovation, Leadership and Transparency of Responsible AI activity (see details in the accompanying table below).

Data is gathered through a combination of LLM extraction and proprietary machine learning tools that surface key data points within company reporting and public disclosures (including press releases, investor relations materials, group-level website pages, group-level social media accounts, and media interviews with senior leadership), as well as a range of third-party data platforms.

This methodology was developed in consultation with leading subject matter experts.

Paramount to our inquiry is that included metrics be transparent, tangible, well-defined, quantitatively precise, and responsive to direct action or investment. In other words, we believe these metrics matter – both now and for the foreseeable future.

45

% OF INDEX
WEIGHT

Talent | measures the number and density of AI & Data employees working at each payments company; as well as the visible initiatives underway to hire, retain, and develop leading AI talent.

→ **Talent Capability:** The volume and density of employees working across the AI and data lifecycle. This includes analysis of 200+ job titles working across four foundational capability areas: AI Development, Data Engineering, AI Software Implementation, and AI Product Management.

→ **Talent Development:** The breadth of initiatives payment companies are deploying to attract, retain, and develop leading AI talent, as well as upskill the rest of the organization.

30

% OF INDEX
WEIGHT

Innovation | measures a payment company's long-term investment in AI innovation, extending to AI-focused research and patents; AI-focused investments and acquisitions; as well as engagement with the open source ecosystem.

→ **Research & Patents:** The volume and caliber of the payment company's AI research output and talent; participation at leading academic conferences; partnerships with academic institutions, as well as investment in and relevance of AI-focused patents.

→ **Ventures & Partnerships:** The number of investments and acquisitions of AI and Data/Tech-focused companies.

→ **Open Source:** The payment company's overall engagement with the open source ecosystem, including direct contributions to leading code repositories and participation in open source projects and workings.

15

% OF INDEX
WEIGHT

Leadership | measures the AI focus of the payment company's leadership, expressed through the company's overarching AI narrative, composition of the executive leadership team, and external communications from select C-level executives.

→ **AI Narrative:** The payment company's group-level AI narrative across direct channels (press releases, LinkedIn, investor relations materials). Includes an assessment of the payment company's "coverage" across media channels (scale), as well as the "content" (substance). Our current inquiry increasingly focuses on how payment companies report on AI use cases and estimated business impact (ROI).

→ **Executive Positioning:** The composition of the payment company's executive leadership team, and strategic focus on AI found across external communication channels.

10

% OF INDEX
WEIGHT

Transparency | measures the extent to which payment companies are focusing on Responsible AI (RAI), as evidenced by the publication of internal processes, establishment of key partnerships, hiring of dedicated RAI talent, and promotion of RAI principles.

→ **RAI Talent:** The presence and scale of internal RAI talent, as well as AI specialists posted across the front lines of defense (including Audit, Legal, and Compliance).

→ **RAI Innovation:** The extent to which payment companies are publicly communicating a wide range of RAI activities, such as through the publication and operationalization of guiding AI principles.

→ **RAI Leadership:** Evidence and assessment of established RAI partnerships, creation of AI governance committees, and/or adaptation of risk management frameworks; tangible outputs in the form of RAI research output, case studies, and use cases.

					
COMPANY	RANK	TALENT Capability & development	INNOVATION Research, patents, ventures, ecosystem	LEADERSHIP in public comms and strategy	TRANSPARENCY of responsible AI activities
Visa	1	2	1	4	2
Mastercard	2	3	3	1	1
PayPal	3	1	2	8	3
American Express	4	4	4	6	4
Stripe	5	6	5	3	12
Block	6	5	7	2	9
Adyen	7	7	11	5	7
Fiserv	8	8	8	7	6
FIS	9	9	6	11	5
Worldline SA	10	10	10	9	11
Global Payments	11	11	9	10	8
Nexi	12	12	12	12	10

AI is a long established competency within the Payments sector

AI is not a new experiment for payment companies. It represents an established core competency that dates back many years. Across all areas of financial services, payments stands out as one of the most technology-forward sectors, driven by the intrinsic nature of the business itself.

The industry operates at enormous scale, in real-time, and under constant fraud pressure – where split-second decisions directly influence losses, approval rates, and customer trust. The result is an environment where AI was adopted out of necessity, not opportunistically. This has driven sustained investment in machine learning, anomaly detection, and rules-based automation well before “AI transformation” became an omnipresent, board-level talking point across every corner of financial services.

Within this concentrated, highly competitive operating environment, AI becomes less a source of differentiation and more a baseline capability. Within the payments sector, AI is not an innovation layer – it’s part of the operating system.

Generative and Agentic AI are uniquely suited to navigate new opportunities (and threats)

While AI has long underpinned payments infrastructure, the stakes are still rising.

On the threat side, AI is increasingly becoming weaponized by fraudsters themselves. On the business side, expectations continue to climb across merchants and customers alike. Meanwhile, new rails, alternative settlement mechanisms, and crypto-based infrastructure serve to fragment the traditional payments landscape.

In this fast-changing environment, winners will be defined by how effectively they evolve their AI capabilities from defensive necessity to strategic advantage. Gen AI and Agentic AI solutions are uniquely suited to meet these challenges.

In the back office, Gen AI replaces static, rules-based approaches with adaptive intelligence across the payments stack – enhancing fraud detection and approval rates through pattern recognition over unstructured signals, while enabling AI agents to reason over policy, handle exceptions, and dynamically optimize routing decisions.

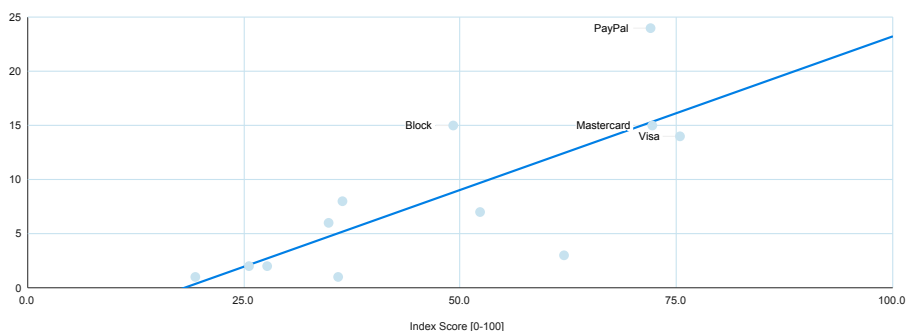
Meanwhile, in the front office, Gen AI and Agentic AI help platforms cut through complexity by summarizing transactions, explaining declined authorizations, generating merchant insights, and accelerating data integration – ultimately reducing friction between merchants and customers.

Early signs suggest the payments companies leading on AI are translating that success into business outcomes

As AI becomes more deeply embedded across payments, a notable shift is also underway.

Historically, payment companies spoke about AI primarily in abstract terms, emphasizing scale, sophistication, or the number of models deployed. Today, a subset of leaders is moving toward more outcome-oriented disclosure, highlighting concrete impact from fraud-loss reduction, authorization uplift, and faster dispute resolution.

PUBLICLY DISCLOSED AI USE CASES, BY
PAYMENT COMPANY

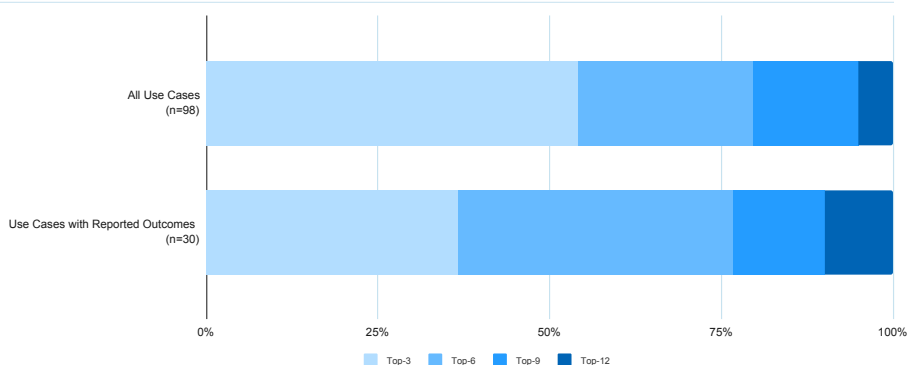


January 2025-2026, n=98 AI Use Cases

Over the past two years, the 12 payment companies assessed have shared nearly 100 AI use cases across press releases and investor relations materials. As shown in the chart below, these use cases are not randomly distributed. Payment companies with higher Index scores drive a larger share of the use cases found.

The three Index leaders account for over half (54%) of all use cases surfaced. In addition, payment companies that rank higher in the Index appear more likely to disclose reported outcomes from these use cases. For reference, about a third of all use cases share impact metrics, including efficiency gains, risk reduction, and revenue uplift. The top-half of the Index account for over three-quarters (77%) of these outcome-oriented use cases.

SHARE OF AI USE CASES, BY RANK POSITION
IN THE EVIDENT AI INDEX



January 2025-2026, n=12 payment companies

Collectively, these observations suggest that years of investment in AI enablers, as measured through the lens of the Index, are starting to pay off – directly translating into more robust use case production and more explicit business outcomes.

While establishing a causal link between enablers and outcomes, the portrait above is reinforced by the “quality” of outcomes being recognized by Index leaders.

Last September, Visa disclosed that their [Scam Disruption](#) practices (which applies AI to map emerging patterns of fraud) had identified over \$1 billion in attempted fraud across 25,000 scam merchants since its inception only a year before. Similarly, when Mastercard incorporated Gen AI technology into its [Decision Intelligence](#) solution, initial modeling showed AI enhancements improved fraud detection rates from an average of 20% to as high as 300% in some instances.

The scale of these applications is on a higher order of magnitude – and impact – than we see across the wider Index. When Visa and Mastercard enhance their network layer with AI, a small number of highly leveraged models can create compounded returns.

Introducing the Evident AI Index for Payments

For payment companies, understanding who is genuinely advancing AI capability – and how they stack up against established leaders – has become a strategic necessity.

The Evident AI Index for Payments addresses this gap by providing the most comprehensive independent benchmark of AI maturity across the world’s leading payment companies. The Index assesses 12 global payment companies using a rigorous, “outside-in” methodology.

As one of the most technology-forward sectors within financial services, payments sits at the front line of AI-driven change. Evident’s mission is to bring clarity to where the sector stands today – and where it needs to go next...

Visa, Mastercard, and PayPal lead the way in Evident's inaugural Payments Index

Visa, Mastercard, and PayPal stand apart due to the consistency of their Index performance across multiple areas of assessment. These three firms occupy the top-3 spots in three of the four pillars of analysis, including: *Talent*, *Innovation*, and *Transparency*.

All three reflect early investment into enabling AI talent, unlocking accelerated approaches to AI development, deployment, and scaling efforts. However, as we will explore below, they remain clearly differentiated from one another – each with its own area(s) of comparative strength.

DISTRIBUTION OF OVERALL INDEX SCORE,
BY GEOGRAPHY



February 2026, n=12 Payments Companies

These established leaders are the only payment companies to score >70 out of 100 available points. This tracks with what we observe in adjacent sectors, where the Evident AI Index has historically identified a handful of AI leaders that achieve a decisive lead over their immediate peers.

Potential challengers to the established leaders – including American Express, Stripe, and Block – all score above the Index average, but trail the leaders by a comfortable margin.

The remaining half of the Index falls below the Index average, buoyed by the stronger performance of Adyen, Fiserv, and FIS. While these three firms sit in different parts of the payments value chain, they each cater to global merchants, core banking, or regulated industries – requiring industrial-grade uptime, regulatory resilience, and global operability.

Head-to-head, Banking leads Payments on most metrics (with some notable exceptions)

Note: While the Index average within Payments (46.9 out of 100 points) is +10 points higher than we observe across either Banking (36.5 points) or Insurance (35.5 points), this does not imply the sector demonstrates higher AI maturity. Individual scores are normalized against their immediate peers, and thereby not directly comparable across adjacent sectors.

To compare and contrast benchmarks across the three sectors Evident profiles, we have compiled a basket of key metrics below for reference.

CROSS-SECTOR PROFILE OF KEY METRICS, ORGANIZED BY PILLAR

PILLAR	METRIC*	PAYMENTS FEB 2026 N=12	BANKING OCT 2025 N=50	INSURANCE JUN 2025 N=30
TALENT	Average Volume of AI Talent	1,826	1,398	814
	Average Volume of AI Talent (Top-10)	2,129	4,260	1,374
	Average Density of AI Talent	6.5%	1.8%	1.5%
	Average Density of AI Talent (Top-10)	7.0%	2.8%	2.1%
INNOVATION	% Publishing AI Research	75%	88%	43%
	Average # of AI Papers	52	47	11
	% Awarded AI Patents	83%	54%	47%
	Average # of AI Patents	121	184	55
	% Engaging in Venture Investments	83%	96%	53%
	Average # of AI/Tech Investments	15	24	11
LEADERSHIP	% Mentioning AI as Strategic Objective	50%	74%	60%
	Average # of AI Use Cases	8	8	5
	Share of Use Case w/ Outcomes	30%	35%	40%
	% Reporting Enterprise AI:ROI	0%	22%	6%
TRANSPARENCY	% Offering RAI Training	25%	50%	33%
	% Publishing RAI Research	58%	68%	20%
	% w/ AI Governance Committee	67%	48%	47%
	% Publishing RAI Principles	33%	48%	40%

* Note: Talent numbers and % adoption stats reflect source/methodology at the time of Index publication. Innovation figures have been normalized to a 3-year trailing period, facilitating direct comparison.

As you can see, banks lead across the majority of metrics highlighted above. Meanwhile, payment companies are distinct in three ways. They demonstrate a higher concentration (“density”) of AI talent relative to overall employees. They participate more broadly in patenting activity (driven by the concentration of payment companies headquartered in North America). And they are more likely to establish AI Governance Committees.

We’ll dive into each of these observations in Chapter 3 (Key Findings by Pillar) – but first, let’s take a closer look at the Index leaders.

THE LEADERS

#1: VISA

The key to Visa's overall performance is consistency, delivering a top-3 performance in 7 of the 10 sub-pillars of assessment. Digging deeper into this robust performance, Visa demonstrates particular strength within the Innovation pillar (#1). This pillar captures what capabilities are actually being created – ranging from in-house research to patenting activity to participation in the broader payments ecosystem via venture investments, partnerships, and open-source contributions.

Specifically, Visa dominates the field with respect to Research & Patents. While 9 of the 12 payment companies actively publish AI-specific research, Visa accounts for over 40% of all matching publications found across the Index. This body of work also generates the highest number of average citations (>10 per paper), skewing 3x above its peer average.

Similar to JPMorganChase in Banking and AXA in Insurance, Visa shares common hallmarks with established research leaders. By investing in a [centralized research](#) function, senior leaders with academic credibility, and hiring strategies designed to attract PhD-level talent, Visa helps define and shape the “cutting edge” of applied research.

Specifically, Visa's recent research has demonstrated a focus on solving core infrastructure challenges required to enable “smart payment agents” that initiate and complete financial transactions on behalf of a user or a business. Such research anticipates the need to proactively address the performance and reliability of enabling or supporting systems. Examples of practical applications tied to core research initiatives include:

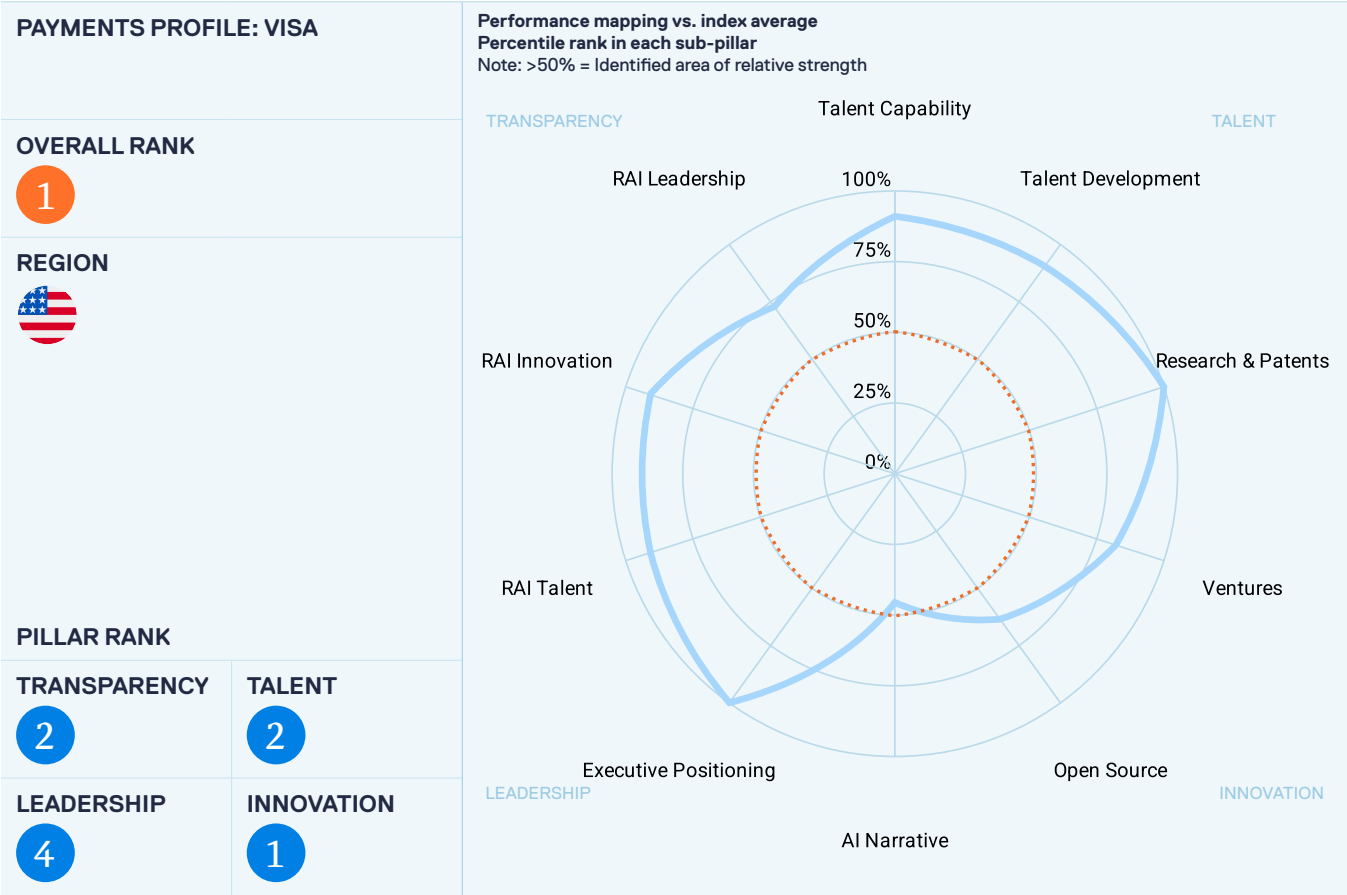
→ Visa's [Scam Disruption](#) practice builds on advanced analytics and generative AI to correlate massive network data, detect scam patterns early, and stop them before they inflict systemic harm – delivering hundreds of millions in prevented losses while strengthening trust in digital payments.

→ Visa's [Trusted Agent Protocol](#) establishes a secure framework for secure, interoperable agentic transactions that could shape the future of digital commerce – leveraging advanced cryptography to distinguish the signatures and intent signals of legitimate AI agents from malicious bots.

→ Visa's [Tokenized Asset Platform](#) (VTAP) helps move tokenization within a distributed system from theory into practice, enabling banks to explore real-world asset digitization and smart-contract workflows that could redefine settlement, liquidity, and cross-border exchange.

Despite Visa's aptitude in building these capabilities, it also shows decisiveness when it comes to acquiring them. In December 2024, Visa completed its acquisition of [Featurespace](#) (\$925M). This investment accelerated Visa's capability in its AI-driven fraud – specifically advanced behavioral machine learning and transaction monitoring.

In short, Visa's research acumen gives it a structural advantage because it combines deep, domain-specific data science with production-scale deployment inside one of the world's most demanding real-time networks. The company's ability to translate experimental research directly into new platforms and improved features for its live systems is a core competency that helps establish (and preserve) the innovation gap observed with respect to immediate peers.



#2: MASTERCARD

Mastercard secures the 2nd overall position in the Index, distinguished by its first-place finish in *both* the Leadership and Transparency pillars. As such, Mastercard is the only payment companies to lead across multiple pillars. These areas of strength underscore the degree to which Mastercard has identified AI as a strategic imperative, aligning stakeholders around a common, long-term vision.

In its most recent [Annual Meeting of Stockholders](#) (April 2025), Mastercard framed Data & AI as a core strategic pillar, emphasizing the need to build products and services using its “*data and artificial intelligence (AI) assets, technology, platforms and expertise*.” The company further identified transformation priorities such as scaling tokenization and authentication, streamlining checkout, and modernizing the card switch to meet the evolving needs of its customers. Each of these initiatives tie directly to where Mastercard is pushing hardest to close gaps with the market leader, fueling recent growth in cross-border transactions and value-added services.

But where Mastercard really stands out is in how clearly it communicates the link between AI strategy and outcomes, especially with regards to two areas of priority investment.

First, Mastercard’s senior executives increasingly frame [AI agents](#) as a structural shift in commerce. In his annual letter to shareholders, CEO Michael Miebach explicitly argues that AI agents will address customer demands and drive “unprecedented personalization, automation, and protection.” That message is reinforced in earnings communications that tie agentic commerce initiatives to near-term execution and strategic partnerships, including its collaboration on Google’s [Universal Commerce Protocol](#) (UCP).

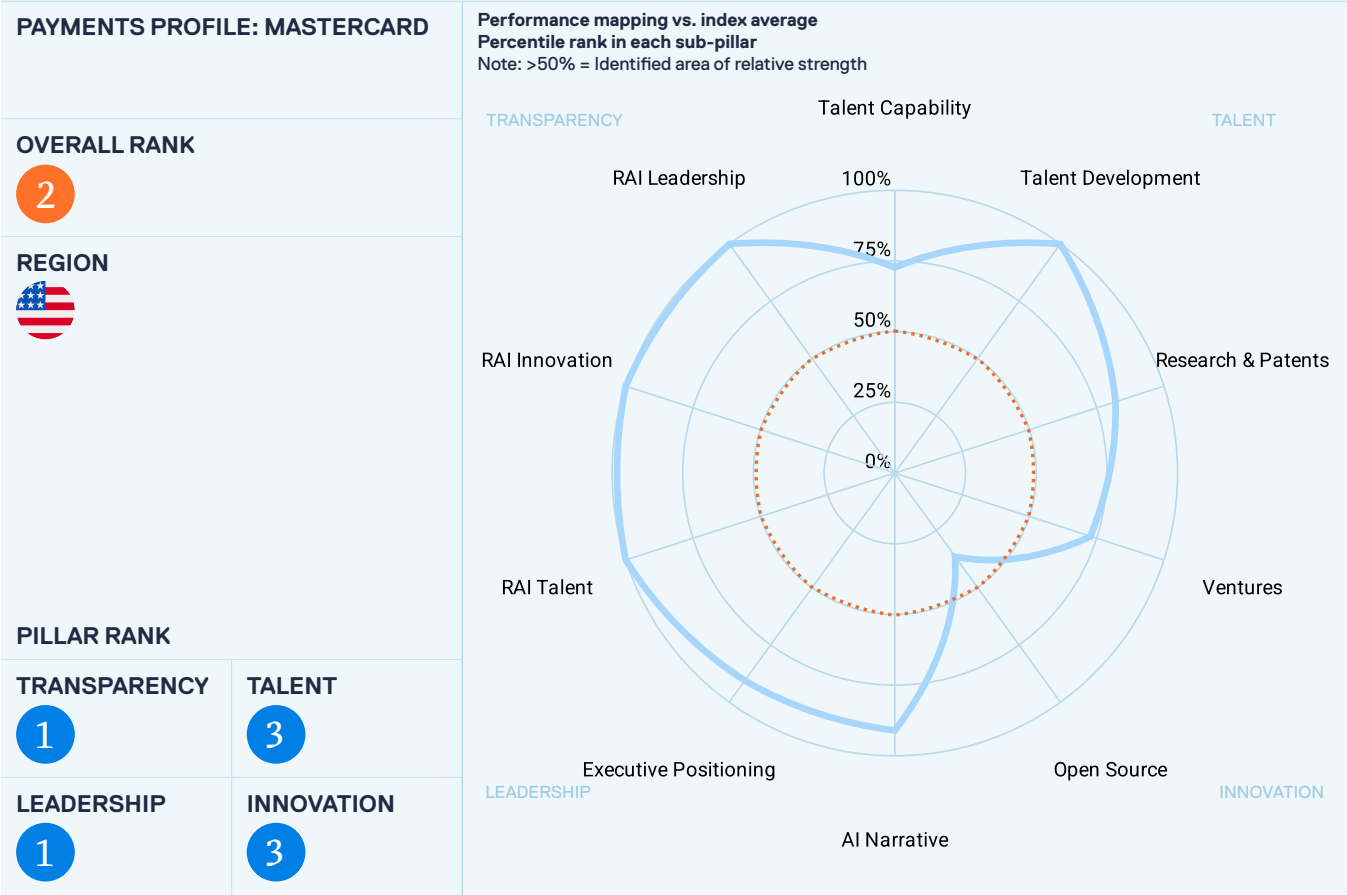
Second, Mastercard has been explicit in quantifying the risk-reduction economics of its AI deployments, particularly [Decision Intelligence](#). The company underscores this outcomes-orientation throughout its proxy materials, describing how adding Gen AI into Decision Intelligence helps evaluate relationships across vast data in real-time and is “enabling us to detect compromised cards twice as fast.”

Together, these examples show Mastercard’s playbook: invest in AI as a foundational capability, channel it into differentiated services that scale across the network, and consistently narrate results in business terms that matter – growth, trust, and measurable reductions in fraud and friction.

Jumping from the Leadership pillar to the Transparency pillar, Mastercard has also adopted a structured, principle-based approach to Responsible AI (RAI) that centers on embedding ethical and governance guardrails into both strategy and execution. It anchors its AI use within a broader [Data & Tech Responsibility framework](#) that explicitly includes principles such as security & privacy, transparency, accountability, fairness, and inclusion. To operationalize these principles, Mastercard has also established a formal [AI Governance Council](#) and joined the [U.S. AI Safety Institute Consortium](#).

Mastercard’s twin strength across these two pillars grants the company a credibility advantage in its big bet on agentic commerce. By framing AI as core to future transaction orchestration, Mastercard sets expectations early with merchants, developers, and regulators about how autonomous agents will authenticate, transact, and settle at scale. Meanwhile, Mastercard’s mature RAI posture, including governance frameworks, explainability, and ecosystem standards, provide trust to partners wary of delegating financial actions to AI systems.

This combination allows Mastercard to move faster in agentic commerce by shaping the rules of engagement – security, trust, and accountability – while lower ranked peers remain more inward-focused on model performance alone.



#3: PAYPAL

PayPal rounds out the leaders in Evident's inaugural Payments Index, virtually tied with Mastercard. Continuing with the theme that different players within the payments ecosystem exhibit distinct strengths, PayPal dominates the Talent pillar.

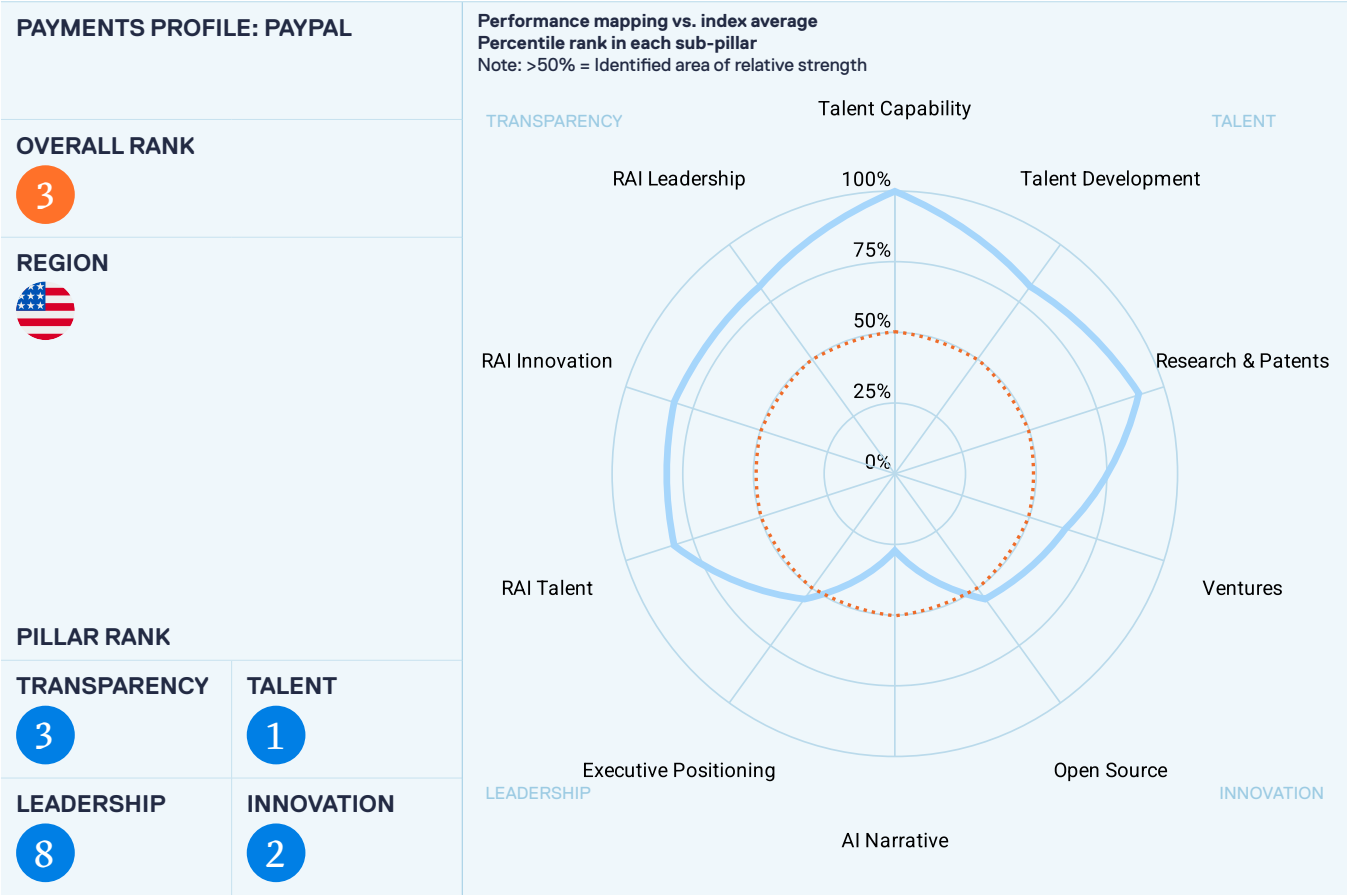
In terms of raw numbers, PayPal boasts over 4,000 AI workers, representing nearly a fifth (18%) of the overall talent pool shared across its Index peers. PayPal's share of AI Development Talent (23%) and AI Product Managers (25%) is even higher. Most importantly, PayPal is not the largest company in the Index in terms of total employees. In fact, it's solidly in the middle of the pack – or only 60% the size of your average card network. Consequently, PayPal maintains the second highest “density” of AI workers (behind only Stripe).

A higher density of AI talent gives PayPal an advantage precisely because its business model extends well beyond operating neutral payment rails. Unlike most payment providers, PayPal owns a complex, end-to-end platform spanning consumer wallets, merchant services, credit, fraud, identity, risk, and checkout experiences – domains where differentiation increasingly comes from software, data, and rapid iteration rather than scale alone.

A deeper bench of AI engineers, researchers, and applied scientists allows PayPal to build proprietary models tightly integrated with its data and workflows, experiment continuously across the full customer lifecycle, and deploy AI directly into product logic rather than as bolt-on features.

In turn, this enables faster product innovation, more sophisticated risk and personalization engines, and greater control over margin economics. To that end, PayPal accounts for nearly a quarter (24%) of the 98 AI use cases documented by its peers over the past two years. This represents 1.7x as many AI applications as detailed by either Visa or Mastercard.

While PayPal's talent profile is critical to pushing forward on a diverse array of use cases, the cumulative outcome (and expense) of these endeavors have recently come [under scrutiny](#). In the wake of incoming [CEO Enrique Lores'](#) recent appointment, questions persist on where and how PayPal's go-forward strategy will impact headcount or alter the broad strokes of the [restructuring initiative](#) announced last July.



1. TALENT

Talent is the key enabler to AI maturity within the payments space. AI-ready organizations depend on skilled teams with deep domain expertise to continuously retrain models, integrate new data sources, and translate AI outputs into operational decisions.

Evident tracks the strength of AI workforces across two areas, allowing us to better understand how companies are configuring their people to accelerate transformation, optimize performance, and realize results.

The **Talent Capability** sub-pillar assesses whether firms have assembled the mix of specialist roles required to deliver across the full AI lifecycle. This includes core AI Development talent to build and train models, Data Engineering expertise to maintain the scalable infrastructure those models depend on, and both Software Implementation and Product Management capabilities to translate technical outputs into deployable tools that can be adopted across the organization.

By profiling the composition of the AI talent stack, we gain insight into different talent strategies at play. Are you hiring *narrow, tactical roles* focused on implementation? Are you hiring *broad, strategic roles* focused on end-to-end architecture? Are you hiring *cross-functional specialists* that sit at the intersection of infrastructure and product?

Meanwhile, the **Talent Development** sub-pillar measures whether firms are sustaining and evolving these capabilities over time through dedicated training, upskilling, and workforce development programs. Taken together, these metrics provide a practical view of how firms build, retain, and evolve the core talent required to deliver AI value at scale.

Given its relative weight (45%) in the methodology, performance in the Talent pillar closely mirrors overall performance in the Index. There is one exception: PayPal, which leap-frogs Visa and Mastercard to take the top spot.

 TALENT	OVERALL INDEX RANK	TALENT PILLAR RANK	TALENT CAPABILITY RANK	TALENT DEVELOPMENT RANK
PayPal	3	1	1	3
Visa	1	2	2	2
Mastercard	2	3	4	1
American Express	4	4	3	8
Block	6	5	5	9
Stripe	5	6	6	7
Adyen	7	7	7	4
FIS	8	8	9	10
Fiserv	9	9	8	6
Worldline SA	10	10	11	5
Global Payments	11	11	10	12
Nexi	12	12	12	11

PayPal challenges Card Networks in overall Talent Volume

Cumulatively, the 12 payment companies assessed account for nearly 22 thousand AI workers spanning four primary Capability Areas: *AI Development*, *Data Engineering*, *AI Software Implementation*, and *AI Product Management*.

The three major card networks (Visa, Mastercard, and American Express) account for nearly half (48%) of this shared talent pool. The high volume of AI talent found at these companies is unsurprising. On average, card networks employ 2.1x as many overall headcount, as compared to a typical payment processor.

PayPal is the lone exception to this rule, featuring an AI footprint directly on par with the major card networks. Unlike traditional payment processors that focus on transaction execution and settlement, PayPal runs consumer-facing products, merchant platforms, digital wallets, BNPL, P2P, and risk bearing services (all under one roof).

In turn, this diverse product portfolio demands AI team specialization across several domain areas, including identity, fraud, credit risk, pricing, personalization, search, recommendations, dispute resolution, and customer support. Additionally, while the typical payment process primarily supports a narrow swath of merchants and banks, PayPal caters to consumers, SMBs, enterprises, platforms, marketplaces, and developers – all with distinct needs and service requirements.

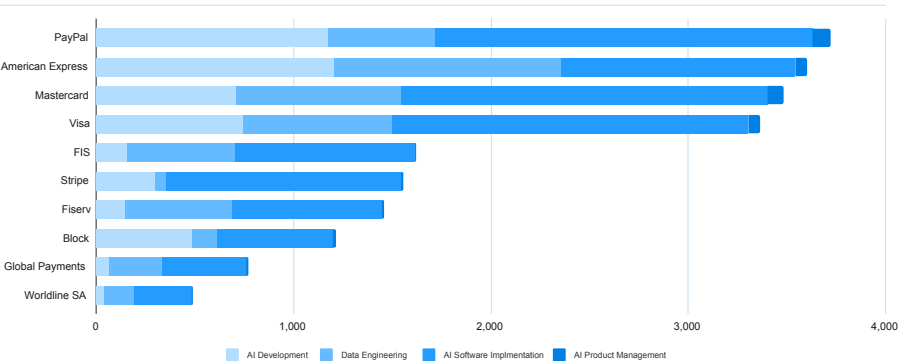
American Express demonstrates advantage in AI Development

Drilling down into individual Capability Areas, we find another big outlier: American Express. Amex features the highest number of AI Developers – accounting for a full third of its talent stack (versus only a fifth for Visa and Mastercard).

This discrepancy is directly attributable to the company’s business model. In contrast to Visa and Mastercard (open networks), Amex operates a closed-loop model, acting not only as a network, but also as an issuer. As such, they require additional AI talent pools to cover the credit lifecycle, as well as consumer experience personalization, offers and rewards.

As a result of Amex owning customer relationships end-to-end, it operates a far more model-intensive AI stack – extending to the full credit lifecycle. This, in turn, drives higher demand for data scientists, model validators, and other specialists.

TOP-10 PAYMENTS COMPANIES: VOLUME
OF AI TALENT, BY CAPABILITY AREA



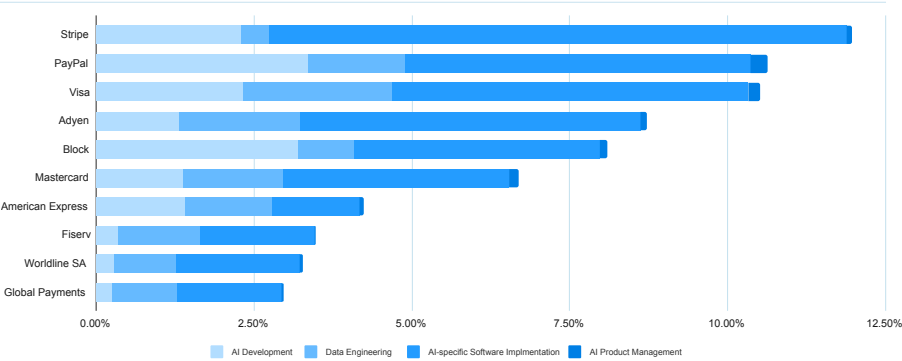
February 2026, n=21,907 AI Workers

Within Payments, nearly 1-in-15 employees are AI workers

Overall talent volumes only tell us half the story. To identify who is most effectively “punching above” their weight class, we also need to examine the “density” of those talent volumes, relative to overall employees.

In aggregate, the 12 payment companies employ nearly 336 thousand workers. Accordingly, the AI-specific roles profiled above account for 6.5% of this overall workforce. As shown below, this density metric varies widely at the company level – from <3% on the low-end to >10% (Stripe) on the high-end.

TOP 10 PAYMENT COMPANIES: DENSITY OF AI TALENT, AS PERCENTAGE OF TOTAL EMPLOYEES



February 2026, n=335,964 Total Employees

Stripe, Adyen, and Block challenges established leaders on AI Density

Within the payments ecosystem, card networks and payment processors play distinct, critical roles. Card networks such as Visa and Mastercard act as neutral infrastructure operators – setting global standards, enforcing rules, and providing the messaging rails that connect issuers and acquirers at scale. Payment processors specialize in execution – authorizations, clearing, settlement, reconciliation, and data services – translating network rules into real-time operational outcomes for banks and merchants.

While card networks exhibit 2.7x greater AI talent volume than payment processors, the two cohorts are more evenly matched in AI talent density (7.2% vs. 6.1%, respectively).

Here again, AI density appears to vary more widely among payment processors. Specifically, the top-3 ranked payment processors (Stripe, PayPal, and Block) stand out in their ability to preserve higher AI density (>10% of total employees) at scale (>2,000 AI staff).

TOTAL VOLUME OF AI TALENT VS. RELATIVE DENSITY, AS PERCENTAGE OF TOTAL EMPLOYEES



February 2026, n=12 Payment Companies

Pulling back, what attributes do these companies share that contribute to a “denser” talent stack?

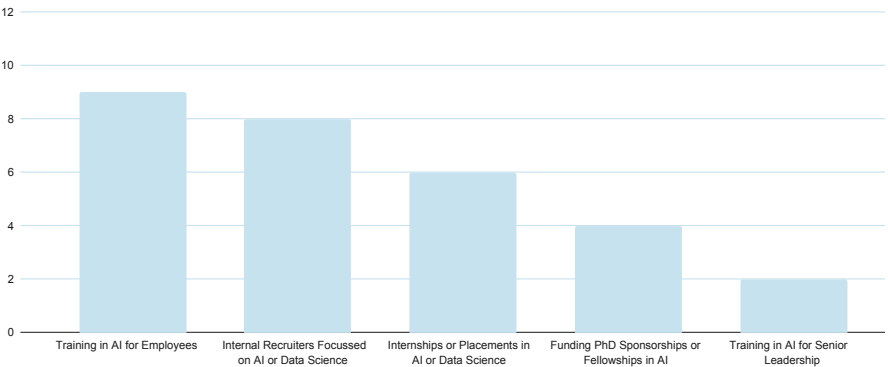
Fundamentally, these outliers differ from their immediate peers in that each leverages its own core software platform, positioning themselves as end-to-end commerce enablers. Not only covering payment processing, but also inclusive of identity verification, digital wallets, point-of-sale software, tax compliance tools, crypto infrastructure, etc. In contrast, more traditional payment processors remain constrained by shallower AI benches focused largely on traditional transaction processing.

Greater ambition across the commerce stack requires more technical resources (and risk tolerance), which leads to a higher concentration and diversity of AI practitioners found in-house at PayPal, Stripe and Block.

Mastercard leads on Talent Development

Volume and density of AI talent will only get you so far. Without organization-wide training and education programs, many AI initiatives will fail to deliver on their promise. While 9 of the 12 payment companies disclose AI-specific training, only six companies have laddered up from general upskilling in AI to topic-specific or role-specific training.

SHARE OF PAYMENT COMPANIES
SUPPORTING SPECIFIED TRAINING
INITIATIVES OR PROGRAM



February 2026, n=12 Payments Companies

While Mastercard drops to #4 in Talent Capability, it earns the #1 spot in Talent Development – signaling active investment to address and close that gap with select peers.

Mastercard is one of only two companies (alongside Worldline) that demonstrates adaptation of AI training to cater to different levels of seniority within the organization. This includes initiatives such as the [Mastercard Academy](#), its internal talent marketplace ([Unlocked](#)), and expansion of the [Mastercard Fellowship Program](#) in AI (in partnership with HEC Paris).

This internal core competency is also mirrored in the tools that Mastercard is beginning to offer to external partners. In May 2025, Mastercard unveiled its [Small Business Navigator](#) program – including AI coaching for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). These efforts not only help scale AI-powered education to Mastercard’s broader ecosystem, but proactively enhance the growing risk of cyber threats within one of the company’s most vulnerable constituencies.

2. INNOVATION

While the Talent pillar assesses whether payment organizations have the technical skills to build and deploy AI, the Innovation pillar shifts focus towards what capabilities are actually being created – ranging from in-house research and patent development to participation in the broader payments ecosystem through ventures, partnerships, and open-source contributions. Tracking these areas of innovation allow us to understand the matrix of strategic approaches used to build, buy or partner across the payments sector.

AI Research enables payment companies to explore new capabilities tailored to specific challenges, including by leveraging in-house research teams or through external partnership with academic institutions. **Patents** serve as both a defensive asset and strategic differentiator, where a strong IP position allows companies to attract partners, influence standards and commercialize AI capabilities. **Ventures**, meanwhile, offer early access to emerging technologies, talent and business models. **Open-source** activity signals a company's engagement with the wider AI ecosystem, reflecting how it contributes to shared codebases and collaborates with external developers to shape standards, protocols, and emerging product areas.

 INNOVATION	OVERALL INDEX RANK	INNOVATION PILLAR RANK	RESEARCH & PATENTS RANK	VENTURES RANK	OPEN SOURCE RANK
Visa	1	1	1	3	5
PayPal	3	2	2	5	6
Mastercard	2	3	3	4	7
American Express	4	4	4	2	7
Stripe	5	5	5	1	2
Fiserv	9	6	8	8	9
Block	6	7	6	12	1
FIS	8	8	7	6	11
Global Payments	11	9	9	9	10
Worldline SA	10	10	11	10	3
Adyen	7	11	10	11	4
Nexi	12	12	12	7	11

Leaders in Innovation have invested heavily across these areas. Visa, Mastercard, and PayPal perform consistently well across multiple innovation channels, suggesting that sustained AI leadership is linked to balanced strategies that pair aggressive research and patenting with selective ecosystem investment. Indeed, the top-5 firms in the Innovation pillar closely mirror the overall Index rank, underscoring AI innovation as a core driver of competitive performance within payments.

A closer look at the sub-pillars, however, reveals meaningful divergence in how that innovation is achieved. Visa and PayPal stand out for sheer scale, with the former leading in research output, whilst PayPal lead in terms of volume of patents, and venture activity. At the same time, Mastercard closes the gap through higher patent quality – as measured by how much a patent is cited – and a stronger track record of targeted AI acquisitions.

Beyond the top-tier, innovation approaches appear to be more selective: Stripe over-indexes on ventures, whilst Block, Worldline, and Adyen focus more of their innovation efforts in open-source engagement. Although this area is weighted less than other areas of innovation, it remains a strategically important channel for payment companies (especially processors) given their delivery models are built around APIs, developer tools, and shared protocols.

Recent activity across the six companies hosting AI-related GitHub repositories suggests agentic systems and protocols are becoming a growing focus. Here, protocols refers to an aspect of underlying agent infrastructure that outlines the shared technical standards, interfaces, and rules that allow agents to communicate, exchange data, and execute actions reliably across platforms.

Tracking these developments highlights how certain processors are using open source as a practical entry point into emerging innovation areas – particularly for those outside the network giants who have historically invested more heavily in foundational research. In a space that remains early and undefined, open source is drawn on to build influence, establish trust, and shape shared standards.

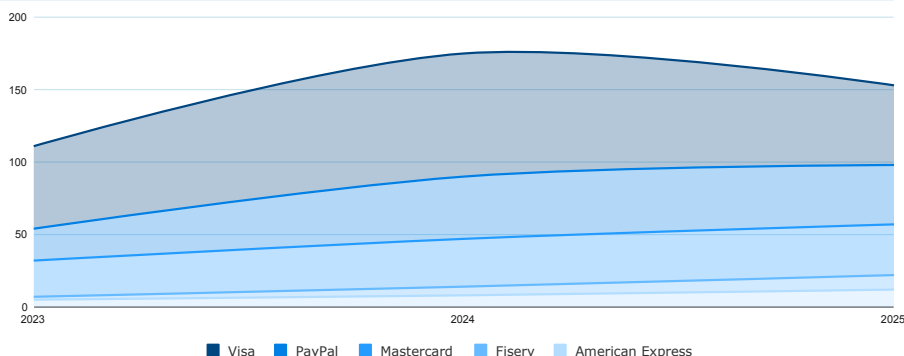
The divergence observed in this pillar highlights a broader trend seen by Evident across the Banking and Insurance sectors. Namely, while investing equally across Innovation areas is a marker of maturity, there remain multiple routes to executing AI innovation successfully – depending on where companies elect to build, buy or participate in a wider ecosystem in order to enhance or augment internal capabilities.

Visa, PayPal, and Mastercard account for almost 90% of AI Research output

While three quarters of payment companies have published AI research since 2023, output remains highly concentrated. Visa, PayPal, and Mastercard account for the clear majority of published work. However, each company's contribution to collective research output varies over time.

Throughout 2023-2024, Visa pulled ahead of its peers with significant YoY growth in research publications, before normalizing in 2025. Mastercard & PayPal show slower, but more consistent growth since 2023, with American Express and Fiserv gradually expanding their small research footprint. This “follow the leader” dynamic suggests that while AI research remains highly concentrated in payments, it is slowly broadening out beyond the top players.

**TOP-5 PAYMENTS COMPANIES:
AI RESEARCH PUBLICATIONS, BY YEAR**



February 2023-2025, n=439

Volume matters, but so too does quality and reception of research. To that end, Visa and PayPal lead the Index in average citations (10+ per paper), indicating sustained research impact rather than mere exploration. Meanwhile, the three research leaders are the only payment companies to participate in academic conferences focused on AI, securing an advantage over peers in terms of visibility and awareness among prime candidates for future recruitment.

Across financial services, strong AI research performance is typically associated with a familiar set of ingredients: dedicated research labs or centres of excellence, senior research leaders with academic credibility, and hiring strategies designed to attract PhD-level talent. Payments leaders have broadly adopted this model, but its execution varies meaningfully. Whilst Visa and Mastercard leverage more centralized R&D units for foundational research, American Express operates a Frontier Research unit and employs a relatively large number of AI researchers yet produces limited public research output – suggesting a greater emphasis on internal, application-led research tied to its closed-loop business model rather than external publication.

2025 has seen leading payment companies begin launching products and staking claims in the nascent agentic e-commerce space. While much of the underlying technical progress is unlikely to appear in published research – given both the commercial upside and competitive intensity of this domain – Visa’s recent publications provide a useful window into the types of foundational problems being prioritized.

Over the past two years, Visa’s research has demonstrated a focus on solving core infrastructure and performance challenges required to enable payment-enabled agents externally, while also improving the robustness and accuracy of internal agentic systems.

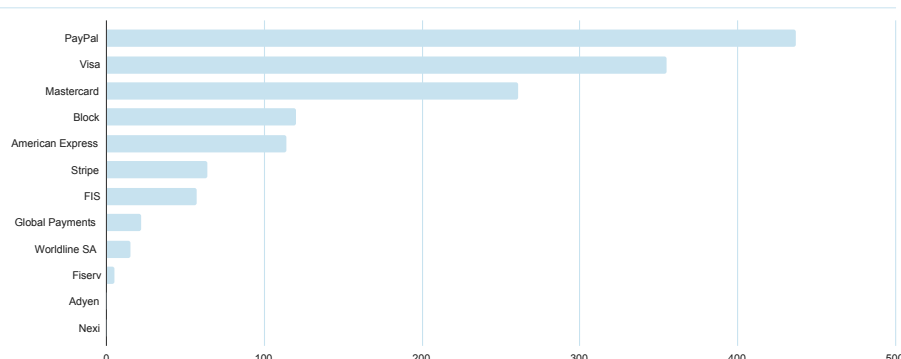
→ [“MAIN-RAG: Multi-Agent Filtering Retrieval-Augmented Generation”](#) → improving the reliability of agentic RAG by filtering noisy retrieval results through multi-agent consensus.

→ [“Low Latency High Throughput Data Serving Layer for Generative AI Applications using the REST-based APIs”](#) → enabling real-time agent performance by building faster serving layers to better supply LLM workflows with fresh transactional and operational data.

AI patents are equally concentrated, but a longer tail points to competitive IP terrain

Again PayPal, Visa, Mastercard consolidate their performance in the Innovation pillar by collectively owning the majority (72%) of AI-related patents assigned to Index companies. Unlike research however, patenting appears to be a much more common practice as you move down the Index. Beyond the leaders, Block – which leads the Index with the highest average citations (12 per patent) – spearheads the long-tail of peers engaged in patenting activity.

NUMBER OF AI PATENTS OWNED,
BY PAYMENT COMPANY



February 2023–2026, n=1,450 patents

Patent leader PayPal has championed a diverse library of protected IP across anomaly detection, trust score generation, and [ensuring fairness of datasets](#). Their patent performance appears to stem from a strong internal culture led by former Head of Patents Alex Courtarde. Specifically, PayPal’s culture prioritized lowering the friction between idea and asset, making it easier for employees to translate innovations into protected IP. This approach has proven particularly important in a highly competitive, consumer-facing payments ecosystem, where product differentiation is a key dynamic. By systematizing patent creation, PayPal has been able to defend core technologies across multiple jurisdictions, even as the [rules around AI patentability](#) have remained uncertain.

Moreover, although patent data is inherently backward-looking due to the lag between filing and grant, two-thirds of payment companies already show evidence of patenting activity tied to newer architectures, including Generative AI and Agentic AI.

Despite wide disparity in overall patent volumes across the index, recent patenting activities demonstrates that a meaningful share of firms are actively engaged in developing and protecting frontier techniques that can be applied to existing and emerging AI use cases:

PATENT NAME	COMPANY	PUBLICATION DATE	DESCRIPTION
“Determining user types from behavior”	Block	December 2025	Behavior-based user classification and orchestration for fraud prevention and account verification
“Return management service”	American Express	October 2025	LLM-powered returns and refunds orchestration (automated dispute/return recommendations + merchant communication)
“Authentication using ai-generated media samples”	Mastercard	September 2025	Generative AI-based authentication (personalized media CAPTCHA / identity verification)

AI-focused start-ups account for 35% of investment activity within Tech & Data venture portfolios

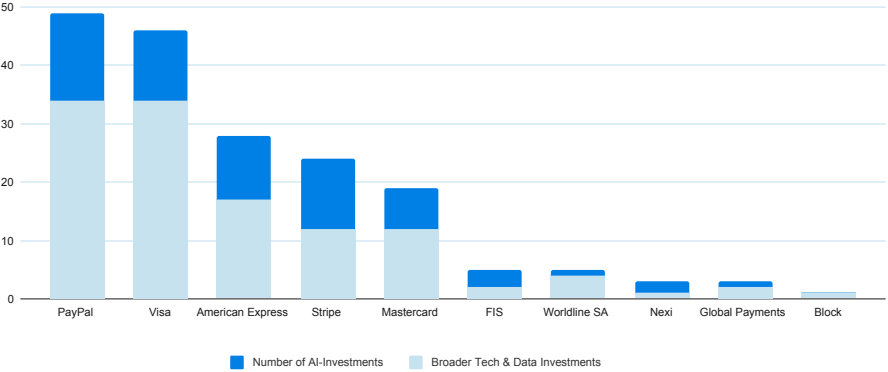
Evident’s data underscores that payment companies vary in their strategic motivations for investing in AI start-ups.

Some adopt a classic venture-capital approach, backing promising companies early through seed and Series-A rounds. Others use early stage investment more defensively – securing exposure to emerging capabilities, monitoring potential disruptors, or positioning for future market share.

Evident tracks this activity not only across AI-native start-ups, but across the wider Tech & Data ecosystem. While AI already represents a material share of overall venture activity, explicitly Gen AI-focused investments remain relatively rare – highlighting that this space remains exploratory, and concentrated among a small number of leaders.

Again, Index leaders PayPal and Visa pull ahead of the pack on raw investment power across tech, data & AI. Yet a strong overall investment push from American Express and Stripe sees them closely trailing, with a particularly AI-focussed portfolio (50%) adopted by the latter.

TOP-10 PAYMENT COMPANIES: TOTAL INVESTMENTS IN AI-RELATED OR TECH & DATA-RELATED COMPANIES



January 2023-2026, n=183 Investments

While the majority of investment volume is concentrated among the top-5 firms, reviewing individual investment choices alongside the rankings helps clarify where each company sits across the spectrum of venture strategies, with leading firms typically pursuing multiple approaches in parallel.

At the more nascent end of the spectrum, firms often begin with a traditional venture-capital approach, making smaller early-stage investments to gain exposure to emerging technologies. For organizations such as FIS, a handful of investments are concentrated on later stage venture exposure to AI start-ups, particularly in cybersecurity and fintech.

Data on higher ranking companies points to how more mature investment is made based on whether a target aligns with their broader innovation objectives. Amex Ventures, for example, articulates how the company targets startups advancing Gen AI in areas such as trust & safety, enterprise efficiency,

and data-driven experiences, with recent investments including **Sedric** (automating compliance review), **Galileo** (building more reliable Gen AI tooling), and **Mindtrip** (dynamic Gen AI-powered travel experiences). What's demonstrated here is an intentional alignment between external investment and internal business priorities.

Another characteristic of firms that lead on ventures, shows how investment activity is used to also secure optionality and early influence in emerging AI categories. In 2025 PayPal's \$18mn Series-A investment in **KiteAI** and Stripe's participation in a \$16mn Series A round for e-commerce AI advisor provider **Remark**, both exemplify this approach: providing exposure to and potential market share in a fast-moving Gen AI domain without necessarily entailing they will adopt those products or applications internally.

Looking at a more committed venture step, where firms opt for outright acquisition rather than minority investment, we see a more aggressive move to internalise valuable capabilities. Mastercard's \$2.65bn acquisition of **Recorded Future** in 2024 is a notable example: reflecting a clearer intent to make use of a massively expanded threat data record and to internalise its [LLM capabilities](#) at scale in existing cybersecurity intelligence solutions.

3. LEADERSHIP

Successful AI transformation requires the mass mobilization of a wide range of stakeholders, including investors, customers, employees, partners, and regulators. This, in turn, requires individuals at the top of the organization to understand the transformational power of AI, and be willing to invest in the long-term future of the company. It further requires setting forth a clear ambition, measurable goals and targets, as well as providing consistent and clear communication along the way.

Payment companies craft their external **AI Narrative** through a combination of investor relations materials, press releases, website collateral, and LinkedIn activity. This empowers payment companies to communicate a clear, strategic vision specific to AI.

When senior executives amplify that messaging – via media interviews, participation at industry conferences, new appointments to the executive committee, or AI-linked compensation targets – it has a multiplier effect. This **Executive Positioning** adds weight and reinforces where and how AI proves central to the enterprise’s strategic growth plans.

For the most mature companies, sustained, structured disclosures on this topic signals confidence in the ability of an institution to provide regular updates on ongoing investments (and demonstrate incremental ROI).

Block and Stripe catapult to the top-3 in Leadership pillar

As shown in the table below, performance in the Leadership pillar begins to deviate from overall Index performance. Block and Stripe surge from the middle of the pack to share a top-3 position with Mastercard. Meanwhile, Visa gets knocked down here – owing to a heavily skewed performance favoring Executive Positioning (#1) over AI Narrative (#7).

Differences in how openly firms communicate AI strategy often reflect where AI sits in the value proposition and how directly it underwrites growth narratives. For platform-centric, developer-facing companies like Block and Stripe, AI is tightly coupled to product velocity, merchant adoption, and ecosystem expansion. Being detail-oriented in external communications helps signal execution credibility to investors and developers alike, which is critical for ecosystem players seeking to disrupt or challenge the status quo.

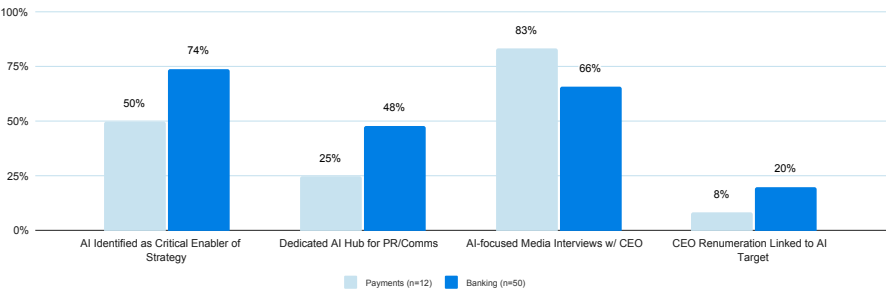
LEADERSHIP	OVERALL INDEX RANK	LEADERSHIP PILLAR RANK	AI NARRATIVE RANK	EXECUTIVE POSITIONING RANK
Mastercard	2	1	1	2
Block	6	2	1	3
Stripe	5	3	3	3
Visa	1	4	7	1
Adyen	7	5	5	3
American Express	4	6	4	9
FIS	8	7	10	9
PayPal	3	8	9	6
Worldline SA	10	9	5	11
Global Payments	11	10	11	8
Fiserv	9	11	8	7
Nexi	12	12	12	12

In contrast, Visa occupies a fundamentally different position in the ecosystem. As a neutral, systemically critical network operator, Visa’s competitive moat rests less on visible product innovation and more on scale, reliability, regulatory trust, and risk management. Accordingly, Visa only references “artificial intelligence” a handful of times in its latest annual report, most commonly in the context of acquisitions (see [Featurespace](#)).

Meanwhile, CEO Ryan McInerney consistently positions AI as a strategic lever reshaping the payments value chain and Visa’s role within it – spanning public interviews with [Bloomberg](#) (April 2025) and investor-facing forums like [JPMorgan’s](#) Technology, Media, and Communications (TMC) conference. In addition, Ryan McInerney is one of only two CEOs whose most recent Executive Compensation detailed a Data or AI-specific target, namely advancing Visa’s enterprise-wide transformational initiatives, including “the adoption of generative AI tools to enhance internal productivity.”

If we pull back to a cross-sector comparison, this reliance on executive positioning appears to be a hallmark of the payments industry.

SHARE OF PAYMENTS VS. BANKING COMPANIES ENGAGING IN SPECIFIED ACTIVITY OR CHANNEL



February 2026, n=12 Payments Companies

AI NARRATIVE	EXECUTIVE POSITIONING
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Only half of payment companies identify AI as a critical enabler to business objectives in strategy docs (annual reports, earnings calls, investor day presentations) versus nearly three-quarters in banking. This observation ties back to the “technology-first” orientation of most payment companies.

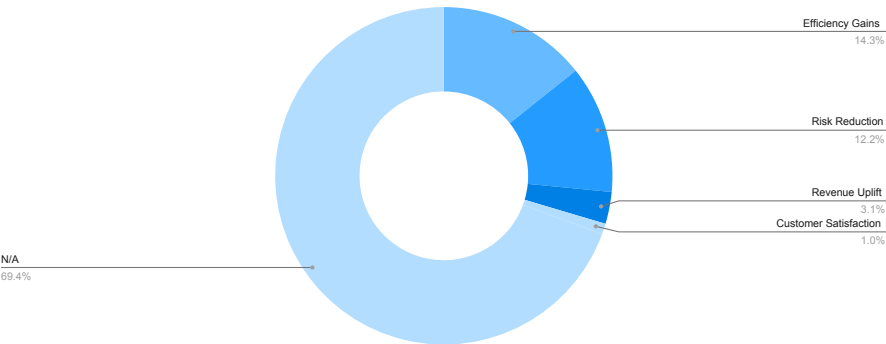
Many strategic levers have elements of AI “baked-in” to corporate objectives (e.g. Tech & Network Innovation, Strategic Partnerships, Product Diversification, and Responsibility/Ethics”), but not called-out independently. In addition, only a quarter support dedicated AI Hubs (see [Mastercard](#), [Block](#), and [Stripe](#) for examples). In combination, this adds pressure to CEOs and other Senior Leadership to spread the word.

Nearly a third of AI use cases shared by payment companies include measurable outcomes

While payment companies opt-out of comprehensive disclosures, they are broadly proficient in detailing individual AI use cases. By examining official press releases and investor relations materials, Evident found examples of nearly 100 AI applications published over the past two years.

Nearly a third of these use cases (31%) include reported outcomes – comparable to the rates we currently observe in our [Use Case Tracker](#) data specific to banking (35%). While reported outcomes in adjacent sectors typically skew towards efficiency or productivity gains, we find the primary focus area for payments is split between efficiency gains and risk reduction.

SHARE OF PUBLICLY DISCLOSED AI USE CASES, BY REPORTED OUTCOME TYPE



January 2024-2026, n=98 AI Use Cases

This observation speaks to the priorities of the sector’s comparatively homogeneous, high-volume customer base. Issuers, acquirers, and merchants all value reliability, low latency, and predictable outcomes over bespoke product differentiation.

Recent examples spanning each category of impact metrics include:

→ **Efficiency Gains:** In July, [Block](#) debuted “Goose,” an open-source agent that lets users find the right model based on their automaton requirements, saving teams 50-75% development time. Block estimates 60% of its workforce already uses the tool on a weekly basis.

→ **Risk Reduction:** In May, [Stripe](#) detailed how its foundation model for payments (billed as an industry first), captured hundred of subtle signals that previous AI models couldn’t, increasing the detection rate for card testing attacks on large business from 59% to 97% (overnight)

→ **Revenue Uplift:** Also in July, [Worldline](#) launched an AI-powered routing solution that analyzes transaction data from acquirers to find the optimal route to increase authorization rates. Traditional rule-based routing is shown to increase authorization rates by +3%. This new AI approach improved on that by another +2%.

→ **Customer Satisfaction:** During its most recent Investor Day, [Block](#) called out operational improvements from AI, including a 25% reduction in manual work hours and utilization of AI tools across 75% of its employee base. The killer app? Nearly two-thirds of Cash App customer service cases are handled by AI, significantly improve response times and overall service quality.

But payment companies fail to disclose overall AI:ROI

While documented use cases such as the ones profiled above help pinpoint where and how payment companies are unlocking return on investment from ongoing AI deployment and scaling, they fail to capture the aggregate impact of all AI activities throughout the wider enterprise.

Across the 12 payment companies assessed, we found no reporting of realized or projected ROI across *all* AI activities. This was surprising, especially given that 10 of the 50 banks we track already do so.

Increased visibility into AI outcomes is one of the clearest signals of organizational AI maturity. Companies that can credibly disclose AI-driven results have, by definition, graduated from experimentation. They have AI use cases in production, embedded in real workflows, and delivering tangible, repeatable value. More importantly, this value is becoming less anecdotal. It can be measured, attributed, and discussed with confidence, implying that performance is being monitored over time, rather than inferred from isolated pilots or proofs-of-concept.

While AI ROI might be intertwined with broader technology improvements for payments, this is also true for other financial services verticals. As payment firms continue to invest in AI, pressure is likely to increase for a more comprehensive articulation of how AI investments impact overall firm economics in the short-term and, longer term, to validate the value created by bets in frontier areas such as agentic commerce.



4. TRANSPARENCY

Addressing risk in AI adoption requires a coordinated organizational effort, spanning technical controls and ethical review embedded into product development, robust validation / testing to ensure risks are mitigated, and ongoing oversight and audit across the lines of defense.

The Transparency pillar provides a lens through which to analyse some of these elements, mirroring the structure of the rest of the Index by concentrating on: (a) who organizations employ to govern AI development (**RAI Talent**); (b) what practical measures they are taking to address AI risk (**RAI Innovation**); and (c) how AI-specific risk, governance, and ethical mandates are reflected in the company's overall public strategy (**RAI Leadership**).

Whilst the top-4 leaders in Transparency match the four overall Index leaders, both FIS and Fiserv significantly outperform peers that typically rank higher, such as Stripe & Block. This might be an artifact of a more deep rooted risk management culture based on who these companies serve. FIS and Fiserv both cater to a highly regulated banking clientbase, where buyers demand robust documentation, governance and controls – setting a strong precedent for enterprise wide AI governance.

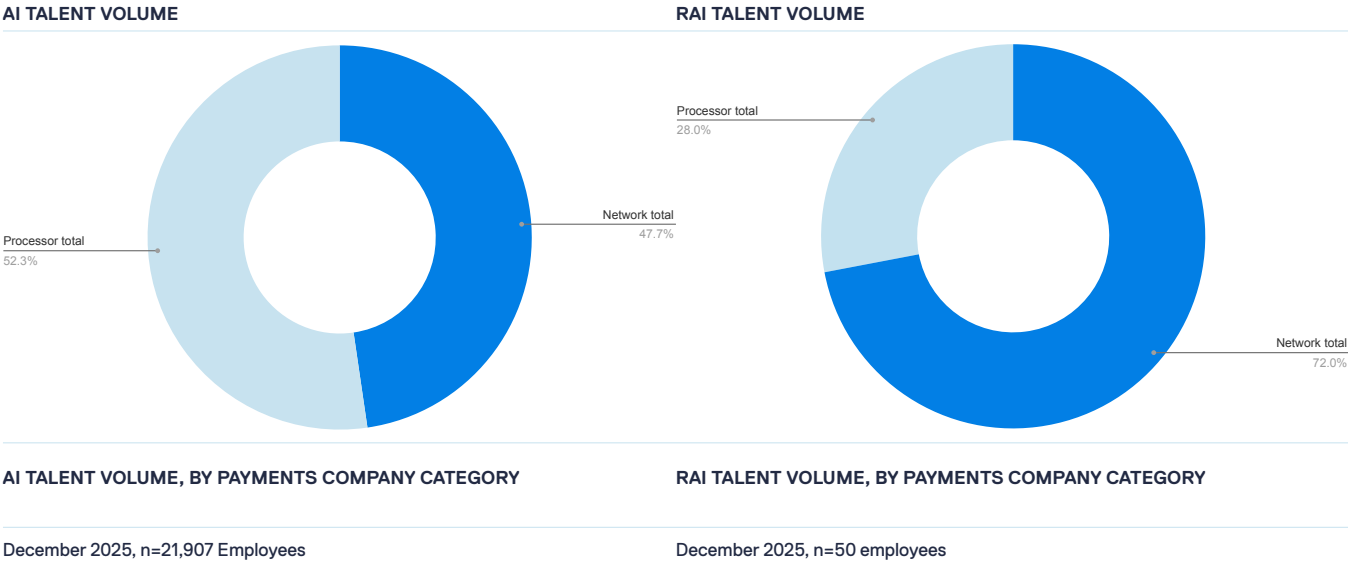
 TRANSPARENCY	OVERALL INDEX RANK	TRANSPARENCY PILLAR RANK	RAI TALENT RANK	RAI INNOVATION RANK	RAI LEADERSHIP RANK
Mastercard	2	1	3	1	1
Visa	1	2	2	2	4
PayPal	3	3	4	3	3
American Express	4	4	1	4	5
Fiserv	9	5	5	7	7
FIS	8	6	5	5	6
Adyen	7	7	9	6	2
Global Payments	11	8	8	8	8
Block	6	9	7	8	12
Nexi	12	10	9	8	9
Worldline SA	10	11	12	8	9
Stripe	5	12	9	12	11

Whilst the RAI Talent base remains low across payments, it points to a bifurcation of governance approaches across Networks and Processors
With long-standing regulatory disciplines in model risk management, third-party oversight, and consumer protection, financial services is relatively mature in managing the risks associated with AI adoption. Leading organizations are increasingly embedding AI accountability into existing governance, risk, and compliance (GRC) structures, while also integrating risk controls directly into the workflows of teams building and deploying AI.

At the same time, the rapid evolution of AI architectures brings with it new threat vectors that necessitate specialist expertise to not only adapt governance models to these challenges, but also support the translation of enterprise principles into rigorous technical controls.

This is reflected in how financial services firms more broadly have scaled their Responsible AI (RAI) expertise – a group of roles that encompasses governance, ethics, explainability, and operational risk. Whilst volumes of RAI talent remain comparatively low versus peers in banking and insurance, the staffing numbers reveal a bifurcation in how card networks versus processors organize around AI risk.

Card networks signal a larger RAI footprint that speaks to the systemic importance of trust, risk controls, and regulatory credibility in operating global payment rails. Meanwhile, payment processors appear to run leaner governance models, likely relying more on embedded compliance or product-level controls rather than an RAI talent stack that lends itself more to explicit ownership for end-to-end oversight of AI lifecycle risks.

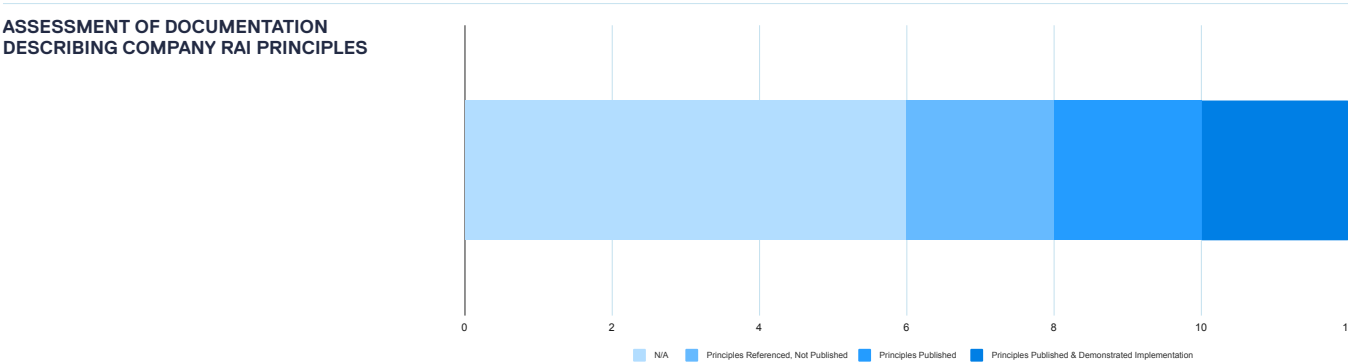


As opposed to reading these figures as direct proxies for governance maturity, they should be taken as just one marker of how firms are adapting to the demands of accelerating AI deployments, where risk ownership must be made explicit and continuously operationalized in a way that is tailored to the business needs of the organization.

Ranked #1 in RAI Talent, American Express, provides a clear example of this juggling act – recently hiring multiple UK-based technical governance specialists, within the company’s EU AI Advisory Team tasked with aligning AI development with the anticipated AI Act requirements.

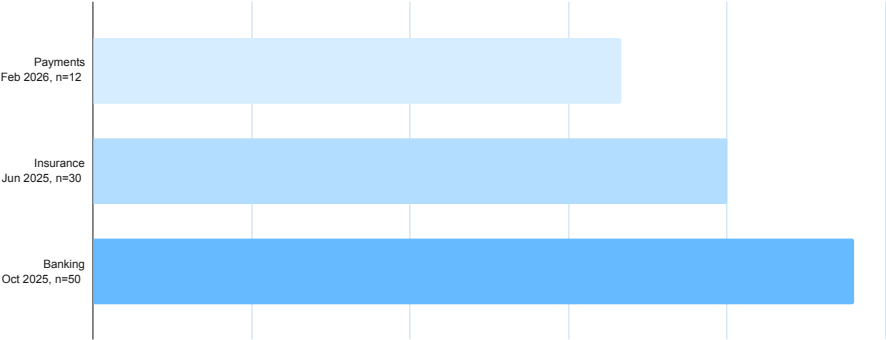
Less than half of payment companies publish RAI principles
RAI principles are another important signal of leadership, providing visibility into the frameworks used to ensure AI is developed and deployed safely and fairly. They provide a binding mechanism for building accountable systems by design, while safeguarding against established and emerging risks such as bias, discrimination, and unintended harm.

Although around half of the payments cohort acknowledge RAI principles at a high-level, only a third publish formal principles. Of these, only two companies (Mastercard and PayPal) provide evidence of operational implementation beyond the published statements.



Payment companies appear less likely to publish RAI principles than their peers in banking and insurance. This points not to an absence of governance, but different disclosure priorities. AI in payments is often embedded directly into fraud prevention, risk scoring, and real-time transaction decisioning – areas where there is less need for transparency with consumers and where publishing detailed principles can introduce potential competitive, legal, and security risks.

SHARE OF FINANCIAL SERVICES COMPANIES
THAT PUBLISH RAI PRINCIPLES, BY SECTOR



Date of Index Publication

Unlike retail banks and insurers, whose AI use cases are frequently tied to customer-facing decisions and therefore invite greater public scrutiny, payment companies may view formal publication as creating unnecessary exposure, particularly where adversaries could exploit disclosures to circumvent controls or where public commitments increase litigation and regulatory risk.

But a majority show evidence of deploying formal AI Governance and Risk Management structures

AI Governance committees and AI Risk management activity is present across over two-thirds of payment companies, signaling a prioritization of internal oversight and risk control mechanisms first, whilst investments into organizational enablement (training) and ecosystem engagement (partnerships) trail.

Meanwhile, we see fairly consistent publication of RAI research (7 of the 12 payment companies), led by research powerhouses Visa, PayPal and Mastercard. Evident’s previous [research](#) has revealed how for some companies, research into emerging areas of RAI – particularly bias mitigation and explainability – is an increasingly valuable way to transfer cutting-edge ideas and experiments into practical tooling that address the complexity of large models and allow for more auditable automated decision making in critical business applications. Within the payments industry – where trust, real-time decisioning, and global regulatory scrutiny converge – Responsible AI is foundational, not optional.

EVIDENCE OF OUTPUTS & PROCESSES
SPECIFIC TO RAI

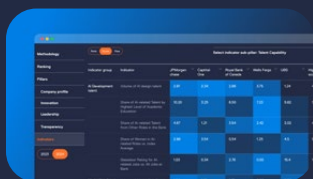


February 2026, n=12

Models must be explainable, fair, secure, and auditable to operate at scale and across borders. Without strong Responsible AI practices in place, technically proficient AI systems still risk regulatory failure, ecosystem fragmentation, and rapid erosion of consumer and merchant trust.

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